more time on these tasks than men. This is one of the highest gender gaps in time spent on domestic work globally. Additionally, women bear the brunt of poor transportation facilities, especially in rural India.

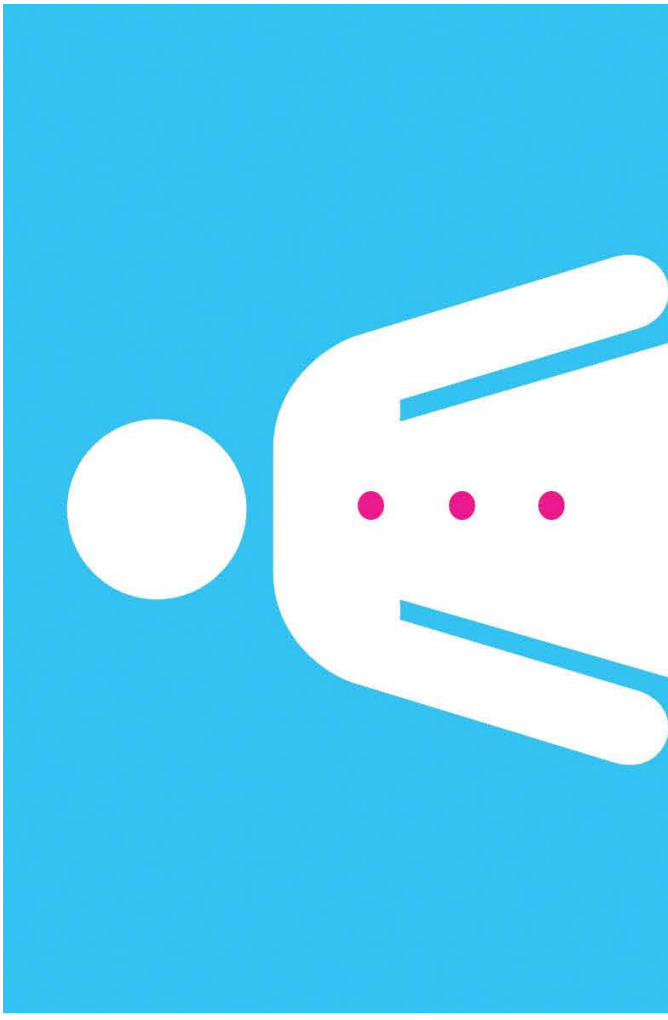
Two, our research shows that low female labour force participation rates (FLFPR) are mainly due to low demand for women's work (fewer jobs overall, for which men are first in the queue). The decline in FLFPR between 2004-05 and 2017-18 can be explained by a decline in the share of employment in agriculture.

Streets and workplaces are not free of sexual harassment or violence, but neither are homes. About 30 per cent of Indian women report domestic or intimate partner violence, which is on the higher end of the global spectrum and, as everywhere else, typically underreported. Staying indoors will not necessarily protect women from sexual violence. Looking forward to 2025, let us create conditions that enable women to inhabit public spaces without fear, as legitimate citizens, second to none. Our cities could begin by planning better, well-lit roads with pavements bustling with pedestrians.

Since 2017-18, India's FLFPR has been steadily increasing. This is partly due to better measurement of the unpaid economic work women have always been doing: their labour on family enterprises (farms, fisheries, poultry, dairy, livestock, kirana shops, making items for sale and so on) that generate incomes for the household. While men working on these enterprises are counted as workers (i.e. in the labour force), women are often not. The other factor is the increase in self-employment. For women, being self-employed predominantly means working either as an own-account worker or as an unpaid helper (and these shares have only been increasing in the past few years), and not so much as an employer.

Given the low FLFPR and poor earnings for women in paid work, are direct cash transfers to women a good way to empower them economically? Analyses of recent elections have focused on the role of special cash transfer schemes for women. While there must always be safety nets for vulnerable, marginalised sections of the population, such schemes cannot be a long-term alternative to regular well-paid employment with decent quality of work ('good jobs').

Indian women's education levels have risen dramatically over the past two decades, and gender gaps have sharply declined. Fertility rates and maternal mortality rates have dropped substantially. Thus, all the preconditions for women to be economically independent are in place—except the most important one: there aren't sufficient jobs to absorb the productive capacity of women. If women are enthusiastically accepting cash transfers, it only indicates that the alternative—uncertain, bottom-of-the-ladder precarious work—is paying them less, and with worse work conditions. The reported excitement around cash transfers should not be interpreted to indicate that women would much rather drop out of (presumably better-paying) jobs to avail of easy cash.



EMPLOYERS SHOULD BE OPEN TO EMPLOYING WOMEN **AT PETROL PUMPS, AS TAXI AND BUS DRIVERS, DELIVERY AGENTS AND EVEN AS MECHANICS**. WE NEED TO CREATE LOW-COST HOUSING AND EFFICIENT PUBLIC TRANSPORTATION FOR THEM

Women's individual willingness to work, even if within easy reach, is not always enough; families and communities